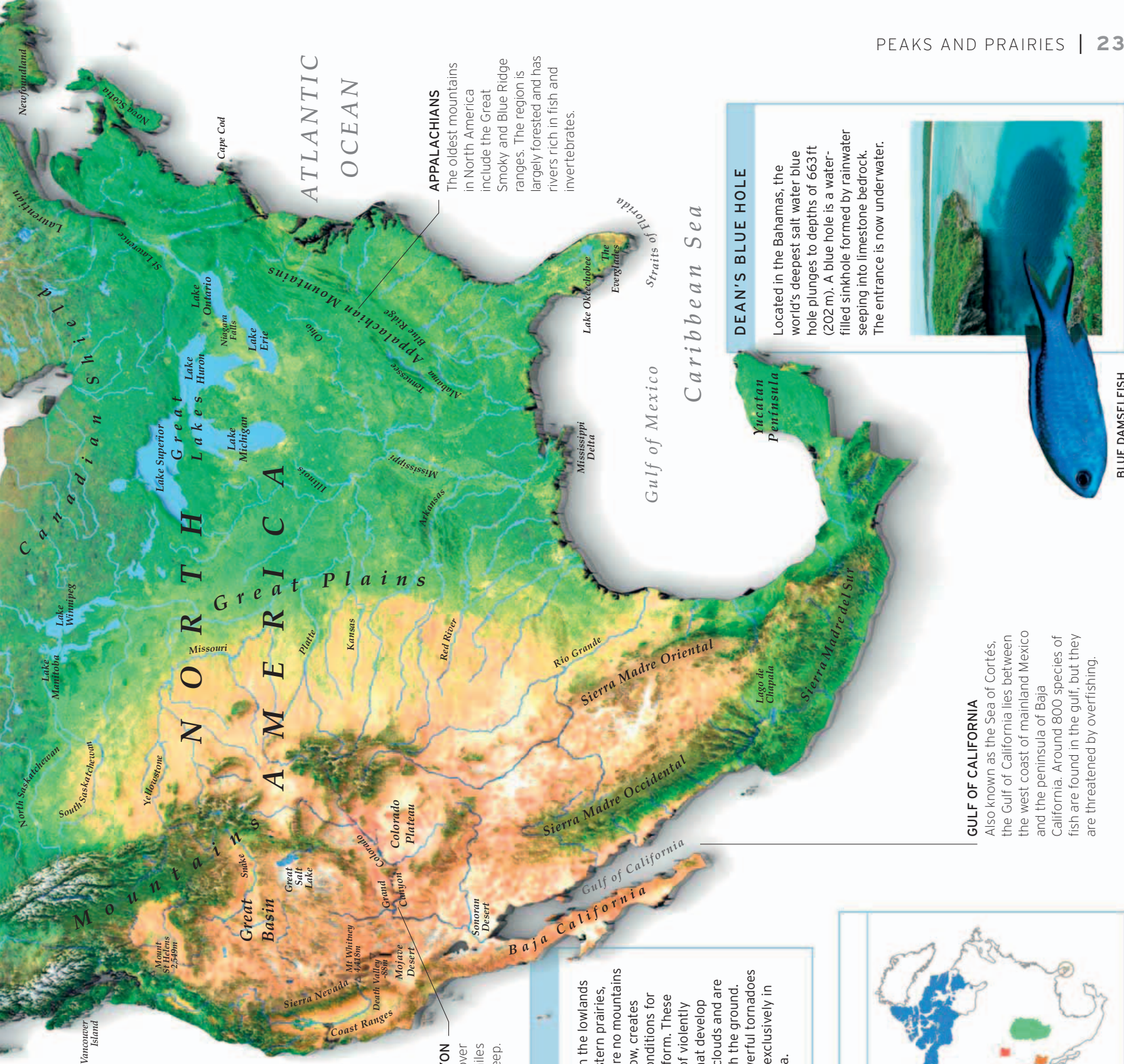




WESTERN CORDILLERA

This chain of mountain ranges includes the Coastal Ranges, Rocky Mountains, and Sierra Nevada, and runs southeast from Alaska to western Mexico. Most of it formed millions of years ago as an ancient oceanic plate moved under the North American plate. This ancient plate has now almost completely disappeared.

subducting oceanic plate

continental (North American) plate

mountain range



GRAND CANYON

Carved by the passage of the Colorado River over 17 million years, the Grand Canyon is 277 miles (446 km) long and up to 1 mile (1.8 km) deep.

TORNADO ALLEY

Late spring on the lowlands of the Midwestern prairies, where there are no mountains to block air flow, creates the perfect conditions for tornadoes to form. These are columns of violently rotating air that develop within storm clouds and are in contact with the ground. The most powerful tornadoes occur almost exclusively in North America.



DEAN'S BLUE HOLE

Located in the Bahamas, the world's deepest salt water blue hole plunges to depths of 663 ft (202 m). A blue hole is a water-filled sinkhole formed by rainwater seeping into limestone bedrock. The entrance is now underwater.

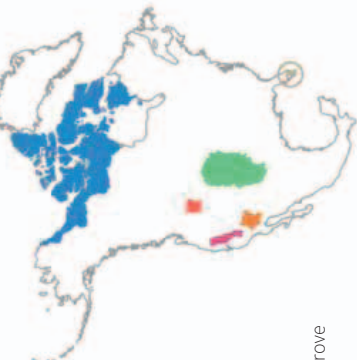


BLUE DAMSELFISH

GULF OF CALIFORNIA

Also known as the Sea of Cortés, the Gulf of California lies between the west coast of mainland Mexico and the peninsula of Baja California. Around 800 species of fish are found in the gulf, but they are threatened by overfishing.

FEATURED ECOREGIONS



- Canadian Arctic » p24-33
Tundra, ice
- Yellowstone » p34-43
Temperate coniferous forest
- Central Great Plains » p44-51
Temperate grassland
- Sierra Nevada » p52-59
Temperate coniferous forest
- Mojave Desert » p60-65
Desert, scrub
- Florida Everglades » p66-73
Wetland: flooded grassland, mangrove